

## Strategy

# “We Evaluate A Segment’s Growth Potential By Identifying Large Market Shifts And Selecting Products Aligned With Those Trends.”

In an exclusive interaction with EFY’s Akanksha Sondhi Gaur and Saba Aafreen, Hykon founder Christo George shares lessons from his entrepreneurial journey and the principles behind building a technology-driven Indian brand, covering innovation, scaling, leadership, and long-term business growth.



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## How do you turn market needs into products, and balance in-house R&D with partnerships?

Battery energy storage systems are a good example. Rapid solar growth has created grid instability, increasing demand for energy storage. Advances in lithium batteries, lower costs, and supportive policies make this a scalable opportunity.

The focus is on aligning real-world needs, technology maturity, cost viability, and policy support. Success depends on identifying emerging sectors and building products around internal capabilities through focused R&D and disciplined execution.

However, SMEs often struggle to retain skilled R&D talent, making long-term in-house expertise difficult. For SMEs, development is more practical than fundamental research. Since core technologies already exist, for them the focus should be on adapting, improving, and integrating them into market-ready

solutions rather than building technologies from scratch.

## What is the expected growth trajectory of this segment, and how do you decide between in-house development and external partnerships?

We evaluate a segment’s growth potential by identifying large market shifts and selecting products aligned with those trends. Falling lithium battery costs, improved lifecycle performance, and potential government mandates for storage integration are expected to accelerate growth.

For development decisions, simpler products are developed in-house, while highly complex projects requiring specialised expertise, such as software development, thermal engineering, or other specialised technologies, are undertaken with government agencies or external R&D partners. Hykon follows a hybrid model in which external partners handle core development, while internal teams

focus on testing, industrialisation, and production-level improvements.

## How should SMEs balance R&D and innovation with limited resources?

SMEs should avoid investing heavily in pure research and instead focus on product development and practical innovation.

At the same time, SMEs should prioritise sales and brand building alongside innovation.

## Can you disclose your R&D, manufacturing strategy, automation, and Kerala-based operations?

Our R&D team comprises around 25 members, including engineers, postgraduate professionals, and experienced specialists with 15-20 years of expertise, ensuring continuity and deep domain knowledge. We are also building AI and automation capabilities through six-month engineering internship programmes with hiring pathways. A dedicated six-member AI team focuses on integrating existing tools such as cloud